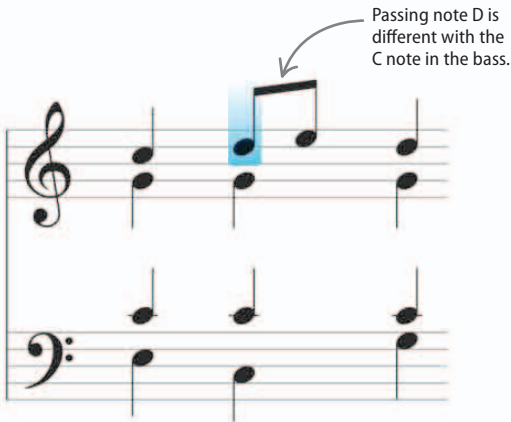


Weak and strong passing notes

Most passing notes are rhythmically weak, and would sound odd if played with an accent. However, an accented passing note can give tension to a chord, which is quickly resolved. In this way, the function of a passing note can be similar to a suspension.



△ A strong passing note

The shaded passing note D is dissonant with the note C in the bass, but it is placed at the beginning of the chord, giving it extra emphasis.

LOOKING CLOSER

Neighbor notes

A neighbor note lies only a major or minor second away from the harmony note—and after visiting its neighbor, the harmony always returns home. The neighbor may lie either above or below the chord tone, and at any place within the harmony (melody, bass, or inner parts). Unlike passing notes, passing notes are non-harmonic in nature and pass the harmony from one chord to the other, without returning to the initial note.



△ What does it do?

A neighbor note tends to strengthen rather than destabilize the sense of the prevailing tonality. Here from D or B, back to the tonic C.

“The sonatas of Mozart are unique: too easy for children, too difficult for adults.” Artur Schnabel

REAL WORLD

A party of passing notes

In these eight measures of Piano Sonata K 457, finale in C minor, Mozart writes several kinds of passing notes. The tempo marking for this music is *allegro assai* or “very quickly.” Thus, the passing notes and suspensions touch in little dabs of dissonance, giving momentum and tension to the melody without disturbing its C minor key center.

Allegro assai

Part of the tonic (C minor) chord

7-6 suspension and resolution

7-6 suspension and resolution

4-3 suspension and resolution

4-3 suspension and resolution

7-6 suspension and resolution

Double suspension 7-8, 4-3

p

i vii⁰⁶ v⁶₅ i i⁶ vii⁰/_{iv} iv v iv⁶ vii⁰⁶/_v v